

ASTR 1270: Introduction to Planetary Science

Fall 2026 • Mon/Wed/Fri 10:00-10:50 AM, Sycamore Hall 120

Instructor: Dr. Rowan Ashby • Office hours: Tue 2:00-4:00 PM, Sycamore Hall 214

Course description

A survey of the planets, moons and small bodies of the solar system: how they formed, what their surfaces and atmospheres reveal, and how we study them with telescopes and spacecraft. No prior astronomy is required; comfort with high-school algebra is assumed.

Grading

Problem sets 25% • Labs 15% • Reading quizzes 10%
Midterm exam 20% • Research poster 10% • Final exam 20%

Schedule

Date	Item	Details
Wed, Sep 9	Reading Quiz 1	Start of class
Fri, Sep 11	Problem Set 1	Due 11:59 PM
<i>Mon, Sep 14</i>	<i>No class: campus holiday</i>	
Thu, Sep 17	Lab 1: Crater Counting	Due 5:00 PM
Fri, Sep 25	Problem Set 2	Due 11:59 PM
Wed, Sep 30	Reading Quiz 2	Start of class
Tue, Oct 6	Observatory Night	8:00 PM, campus observatory
Fri, Oct 9	Problem Set 3	Due 11:59 PM
Wed, Oct 21	Midterm Exam	In class, Sycamore Hall 120
Thu, Oct 29	Lab 2: Spectra of the Gas Giants	Due 5:00 PM
<i>Mon, Nov 2</i>	<i>No class: mid-semester break</i>	
Wed, Nov 11	Reading Quiz 3	Start of class
Fri, Nov 13	Problem Set 4	Due 11:59 PM
Fri, Nov 20	Research Poster Proposal	Due 11:59 PM
Mon, Nov 30	Research Poster Session	Science atrium, Mon-Wed
Fri, Dec 4	Problem Set 5	Due 11:59 PM
Tue, Dec 15	Final Exam	8:00 AM, Sycamore Hall 120

Policies

Problem sets and lab reports are due at the times listed and lose 10% per day late.
Reading quizzes cannot be made up, but your lowest quiz score is dropped.
Bring a calculator to both exams; notes and phones are not allowed.